

Normand 1818

Le cri de la vérité, ou Lettre aux prêtres dissidens — Vingt-troisième mensonge (*The Cry of Truth, or Letter to the Dissident Priests — The Twenty-Third Lie*)

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- French text from the Google Books scan of the 1818 Tours edition, pp. 50–55; OCR corrected against the page images. Old spellings (*dissidens*, *enfants*) retained.
- Translation of the original text performed by AI (*claude-fable-5*).
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- Selection pages: 50-55 (*Vingt-troisième mensonge*)

Note on this selection: universal acceptance argued in the field, against a living remnant-church. The Petite Église — the network of clergy and faithful who refused the Concordat of 1801, treating Pius VII as a betrayer of the old order and, in the writings of Blanchard, Gachet, and “Mériel Bucy,” as a false pope fallen from the pontificate — claimed for itself the very criterion this repository documents: “puis-je être apostat en suivant l’Église universelle?” Normand’s whole reply is to make the criterion serious: the universal Church is not a slogan but a public, identifiable body, and it manifestly adheres to Pius VII — hence the hammering interrogative battery (“Does the universal Church treat Pius VII as a false pope? Answer!”), each question forcing the dissident to concede that the body he invokes is against him. Around the battery stand the standard authorities: Trent sess. 23 c. 8 (bishops instituted by the pope are legitimate bishops, anathema on deniers); the rule that private persons cannot constitute themselves judges of controversies; St. Thomas’s definition of the schismatic (refusing subjection to the pope or communion with his members); Pius VII’s brief of 16 September 1818 confirming the London vicar apostolic against Blanchard’s party; and Jerome’s taunt against the Luciferians — gather every scattered flock of the Rochelais, Poitou, and Maine and you will not fill the island of Sardinia: “if the Church, the inheritance of the Nations, is reduced to your island, then Christ has become poor indeed.” The paucitas-versus-orbis

argument of Cyprian (0251 entry, c. 24) and Bernard (1132 entry, Ep. 126 §11), redeployed in 1818 against the first modern sedevacantism — four decades before Gridel taught the same rule to catechism classes (1861 entry).

The Twenty-Third Lie (pp. 50–55)

THE TWENTY-THIRD LIE. — “If I am an apostate, then it is Jesus Christ who deceives us: can I be an apostate while following the universal Church?” (MÉRIEL, p. 25.)

Dissident writers, the lie must have become your cherished idol, for you to dare resort to it with so presumptuous a confidence: you follow the universal Church! But does the Church wish Pope Pius VII to be denounced for having violated the holy rules? (BLANCHARD.) And in case Sieur Blanchard should proceed to that folly, does she wish the Pope to be held as judged, before the outcome such a denunciation might have? Answer.

Does the universal Church treat Pius VII as a false Pope? (GACHET.) Answer. — Does the universal Church regard Pope Pius VII as fallen from the honor of the Priesthood, from all the prerogatives attached to the sovereign Pontificate, from all ecclesiastical jurisdiction, and from all right to the obedience of the faithful? (GACHET.) Answer. — Does the universal Church regard Pope Pius VII as being as much a stranger to the Church as the pagan and the publican? (GACHET.) Answer. — Does the universal Church regard the name of Pope Pius VII as a blasphemy? (GACHET.) Answer. — Does the universal Church treat Pope Pius VII as a concordatist heretic? (MÉRIEL.) Answer. — Does the universal Church know of any concordatist heretics, the Concordat never having been condemned? Answer. — Has the universal Church abjured the decree of the holy Council of Trent, which anathematizes those who dare to say that Bishops instituted by the sovereign Pontiff are not legitimate Bishops? Answer. — Has the universal Church abjured the decrees of the Councils of Florence and of Basel on the full power of the Pope? Answer. — Has the universal Church abjured the holy rules which forbid private persons to make themselves judges of controversies? Answer.

What! you follow the universal Church, and there is no absurdity that frightens or disconcerts you, when she must serve as your support! For example, you sound the cry of victory every time you cite St. John, who commands us to flee heretics; very well — you prove by this how great strangers you are to sound Theology and to Canon law: who does not know that the Holy Spirit commands flight from heretics? We grant it to you; but the manner of the flight, the public rupture of Communion with heretics, must be regulated, not by Scripture, but by the Church, who is its interpreter.

The universal Church directs herself, in this matter, by the decrees of the Popes and by the decrees of the Councils, because the interpretation of the holy Books belongs to the authority of the Church, and not to individuals; otherwise there would be as many heresies as persons: most heresies have taken their source in the liberty the innovators have given themselves of interpreting the holy Books. [...] Into how many errors would we fall, if we made ourselves, as you do, both judges of controversies and interpreters of the holy Scriptures? Is that the course recognized by the Church? Answer. And you follow the universal Church! No, dissident Priests, you do not follow her — far from it! you have broken all the bonds of unity, and made every shadow of catholicity disappear.

We call schismatic, says St. Thomas, those who will not submit themselves to the sovereign Pontiff, or communicate with the members who are subject to him; this is the venerable authority which the Grand Almoner of France and the Bishop of London, vicar

apostolic, have just recalled to the dissidents of London. The Journals are at this moment publishing the brief of His Holiness, of September 16, 1818, in which the most holy Father seals with his authority the ordinance of that worthy Prelate concerning the dissidents of London: but what will the judgment of the Vicar of Jesus Christ — against whom you have raged with such fury — accomplish upon your minds?

You will not fail to avail yourselves once more of the universal Church against this brief: is the universal Church formed of a few cantons of the Rochelais, of Poitou, of Maine? Is that the universal Church? Take up all your multipliers, or sound the trumpet through the whole universe; recruit all the volunteers who may wish to belong to you; gather all your scattered flocks — you will not fill the little island which the madman Lucifer wished to be the catholic Church: “If the Church, which is the inheritance of the Nations, is reduced to your island,” St. Jerome wrote to him, “then Christ has become poor indeed!”

And yet there, dissident Priests, according to you, is the whole catholic Church of the earth! there is all that the almighty God promised to Abraham for an inheritance! What incorrigible dreamers you are! Ah, at least parade before us no longer your pretended marks of unity, of sanctity, of catholicity; and consider it a dream no less absurd to believe yourselves apostolic. By what gate did you enter your ministry? by that of Jesus Christ, or by that of the Cores, the Dathans, the Abirons? At the head of your little churches I see only suspended priests: and you call yourselves apostolic, while you do not even obey the Bishops whom the apostolic authority has given you! “We do not recognize them,” you say; but in this you are schismatics, struck with anathema by the holy Council of Trent. Answer then: Who sent you into the sheepfold? [...]